

Historical Movements & Frameworks Echoing A Curious Tractor's Philosophy

Movements Practicing Decentralization & "Becoming Unnecessary"

- **Civil Rights Popular Education (1950s–60s):** In the U.S. civil rights movement, leaders like **Ella Baker** and **Septima Clark** stressed empowering the grassroots so much that organizers would "work themselves out of a job." Baker famously said "*Strong people don't need strong leaders*," and both women embodied the idea of "**becoming unnecessary**" as a mark of success ¹. They helped train local people (through groups like SNCC and Highlander Folk School) to lead their own freedom struggles, so the movement wouldn't rely on outside "experts." This decentralizing approach – *facilitators instead of directors* – ensured communities gained ownership of the change. As one account notes, Baker and Clark "*modeled accompaniment, not control*" and valued **handing over power** to the people ².
- **"Work Yourself Out of a Job" in Community Development:** Many anti-poverty and development initiatives explicitly set an exit goal. For example, the Jubilee House Community in Nicaragua describes partnering with locals so that "*if we do it right, every day we're working hard to work ourselves out of a job*." Their role is to transfer skills and power until the community leads and the outsiders become unnecessary ³. This ethos of **planned obsolescence** in social projects has roots in post-colonial and participatory development movements since the 1970s. The idea is that the highest honor for such practitioners is to become irrelevant because the community is self-sufficient – echoing what you call "*Beautiful Obsolescence*." It's essentially a **decolonizing** approach: measure success by how well locals can continue without you.
- **Zapatista Autonomous Communities (since 1994):** The Zapatista movement in Chiapas, Mexico provides a powerful example of **community sovereignty and decentralization**. After their 1994 uprising, the EZLN rebels did *not* install themselves as new rulers. Instead, they "**stepped back and allowed indigenous 'autonomous communities' to decide how to govern themselves, a philosophy they term 'mandar obedeciendo'**" – "leading by obeying." The Zapatistas continuously submit decisions to community assemblies rather than top-down orders ⁴. Notably, Subcomandante Marcos famously abdicated his leadership role, even "**dying**" as a public persona to make way for indigenous leaders ⁵. **This movement shows a radical political ontology in practice: activists act as initial catalysts but deliberately cede power** to the community, aiming for a future where communities govern and the instigators fade out.**
- **Cooperative & Mutual Aid Movements:** Historical cooperative movements also embody "*labor as the art of becoming unnecessary*." The **19th-century cooperative movement** (e.g. Rochdale Pioneers) was about workers and communities taking control of economic life so they wouldn't depend on capitalist owners. In the Basque region of Spain, the **Mondragón Cooperative (est. 1956)** grew into a federation of worker-owned businesses explicitly designed to **eliminate exploitative models**. Mondragón's mission has always been rooted in **grassroots management, equitable wealth-sharing, and community development** rather than profit for

outsiders ⁶ ⁷ . Today Mondragón's network of 90+ co-ops (80,000 workers) thrives by democratic principles – proving that **“there are fairer and more sustainable ways of doing business”** that make predatory corporate models obsolete ⁸ . Likewise, mutual aid societies and community trusts (from historic Black mutual aid networks to modern “Exit to Community” startups) show how people organize to meet needs collectively, so external authorities or extractive middlemen become irrelevant.

- **Indigenous Self-Determination:** Many Indigenous-led movements also prioritize structures where outside institutions *become unnecessary*. For instance, the principle of **“Land Back”** movements is to restore land and governance to Indigenous communities, so they regain full self-reliance. In the realm of data and knowledge, First Nations in Canada developed the **OCAP principles** (Ownership, Control, Access, Possession) to assert sovereignty over their data. These ensure that any research or technology involving them answers to their community's needs and **refuses extraction** ⁹ ¹⁰ . This insistence that *only questions of liberation and joy be answered* by data/AI aligns with your **“Intelligence Ethic”** – it has clear precedent in Indigenous data sovereignty frameworks that treat information as a sacred communal asset.

In sum, from Ella Baker to the Zapatistas, and from cooperatives to decolonizing projects, history shows **“radical work”** traditions where the aim is to *“ignite, lift, separate, disappear.”* A Lao Tzu quote from 2,500 years ago perfectly captures this timeless idea: *“A leader is best when people barely know he exists... when his work is done, his aim fulfilled, they will say: we did it ourselves.”* ¹¹ . Across these movements, **decentralized governance, community ownership, and planned obsolescence of the change-makers** are recurring themes.

Frameworks & Mental Models for Relational Partnerships

- **Asset-Based Community Development (ABCD):** This is a grassroots methodology that flips the script on traditional top-down aid. Instead of outsiders delivering solutions, ABCD practitioners **host the conditions** for locals to discover and mobilize their own capacities. It starts with mapping out the community's **existing strengths, gifts, and assets** (skills, local associations, cultural riches) rather than its deficiencies ¹² ¹³ . By linking these micro-assets to bigger opportunities, communities drive their own development. The facilitator's role is akin to a gardener preparing soil: nurturing local talents and connections, then stepping back. ABCD's success in many locales has shown that **when people co-create solutions from their own assets, they not only solve problems sustainably but also gain power**. This framework encourages a *relational partnership* mindset: sit alongside the community as a partner, not above as an expert, and design every “intervention” as a path to eventual exit.
- **Community Co-Design & Participatory Methods:** A range of **participatory design and research frameworks** can help operationalize the *“beautiful obsolescence”* discipline. For example, **Community-Based Participatory Research (CBPR)** in public health ensures that community members are equal partners in inquiry. All phases of the process are shared – from deciding the questions to collecting data and taking action – with an **“empowering, power-sharing process”** at its core ¹⁴ . This ensures the *knowledge* produced serves community sovereignty and builds local capacity (mirroring your Intelligence Ethic). Similarly, **popular education** (à la Paulo Freire) and **human-centered design** workshops invite community members to be co-creators of solutions. Techniques like **“Art of Hosting”** conversations, **Open Space Technology**, or **design thinking jams** treat the facilitator as a host who convenes stakeholders to collaborate creatively. All these methods share a mental model: *those affected by a challenge should design the solution*, with external experts only as catalysts. Over time, this

collaborative practice strengthens relationships and trust – the glue of any relational partnership
– and ensures the community’s voice leads, not just participates.

- **Relational Leadership & “Servant” Teams:** To drive forward partnerships that are truly relational, the culture of the team itself must shift. Frameworks like **Servant Leadership** (from Robert Greenleaf’s work) and modern *“Teal organization”* models (per Frederic Laloux) emphasize that leaders should **serve the team and then let go**. In practice, this means designing every project with a **handover in mind** – e.g. creating living documentation, training local stewards, and using tools like transparent dashboards or AI agents that community members can eventually run. Teams adopt mental models such as *“we are successful when we’re no longer needed”* or *“plan the exit from day one.”* A concrete example is how open-source software communities operate: a founder might start a project, but through shared governance (codes of conduct, meritocratic contributions), the community takes collective ownership. **Mentorship and network-weaving** are key practices here. For instance, *network weaving* is a methodology where an initial connector actively links people and then gradually steps back as those network ties strengthen on their own. Adopting these models helps practitioners show up “like a rocket booster” – providing initial thrust and guidance – and then joyfully **detaching** as the collective finds its orbit.
- **Solidarity Economy & New Measures of Value:** Driving relational partnerships also requires reimagining the economic narratives that underpin them. **Adventure-based or solidarity economics** is about valuing **relationships, joy, and mutual aid as ends in themselves**, not just as means to profit. We see this in frameworks like the **Solidarity Economy**, which encompasses cooperatives, gift circles, and community trusts. It’s *“an alternative framework... open to continual change,”* grounded in principles of **cooperation, mutualism, equity, and sustainability** rather than competition ¹⁵ ¹⁶. In practice, this might involve collaborative financing models (community grants, rotating savings groups), or measuring success in terms of increased community well-being and autonomy (e.g. Bhutan’s **Gross National Happiness** index, or doughnut economics metrics). For a creative mental model, think of money as a **“river”** flowing through a community (as in your Life OS vision) – each dollar is tasked with making someone *more* free, creative, or connected. Methods like **participatory budgeting** let communities decide how funds are used, reinforcing sovereignty over resources. And at a more playful level, **gift economy experiments** (from Indigenous potlatch ceremonies to Burning Man festivals) demonstrate economic exchanges fueled by generosity and art. These inspire partnerships to move from transactional to **relational**: partners ask “How does this venture increase our collective freedom and trust?” and design agreements accordingly (e.g. revenue-sharing that pours back into community projects, or impact investments that treat funders as co-dreamers rather than owners ¹⁷ ¹⁸).

By studying and drawing on these movements and methodologies, **A Curious Tractor** can find both inspiration and practical roadmaps. The through-line is clear: *to “drive this forward,” stay curious and subversive in how you partner*. Treat every initiative as a learning adventure with allies, rather than a service delivery to clients. Embrace frameworks that center on **local leadership, shared power, radical transparency, and iterative handover**. Historical precedents show that when done with integrity, this approach not only yields innovative outcomes but also builds a legacy where communities celebrate their own power – and fondly remember the catalyst that *“danced in the dust”* with them before disappearing.

Sources:

- Diana P. Wu, *Reimagine!* – on Ella Baker & Septima Clark’s approach ¹ .

- JHC-CDCA Blog – “*working ourselves out of a job*” in development work ³ .
- A. Reuss, *The Progressive* – describing Zapatistas “leading by obeying” ⁴ .
- El País (English) – on Subcomandante Marcos stepping back for a new generation ⁵ .
- **Mondragon Corporation** – cooperative values and community impact ⁶ ⁸ .
- First Nations Information Governance Centre – **OCAP data sovereignty principles** ⁹ ¹⁰ .
- Oxford Review – definition of **Asset-Based Community Development** ¹² ¹⁹ .
- CAPHE Detroit – on **equitable partnerships** in CBPR (community research) ¹⁴ .
- AWID – overview of **Solidarity/Gift economy** values and principles ¹⁵ ¹⁶ .
- Lao Tzu (Tao Te Ching verse 17) – “*when his work is done... they will say: we did it ourselves.*” ¹¹ .

¹ ² Voices from the Immigrant Rights Movement: by Diana Pei Wu

<https://www.reimaginerpe.org/book/export/html/1083>

³ Sidelineing Ourselves: Power Dynamics and the Fight Against Poverty — JHC-CDCA

<https://www.jhc-cdca.org/blog/sidelineing-ourselves>

⁴ Mexico's Zapatistas Fight for a New Kind of Politics - Progressive.org

<https://progressive.org/op-eds/mexico-s-zapatistas-fight-new-kind-politics/>

⁵ Winds of change for the EZLN: The second death of Subcomandante Marcos | International | EL PAÍS English

<https://english.elpais.com/international/2023-10-31/winds-of-change-for-the-ezln-the-second-death-of-subcomandante-marcos.html>

⁶ ⁷ Introduction, MONDRAGON Corporation | MONDRAGON Corporation

<https://www.mondragon-corporation.com/en/about-us/>

⁸ How Mondragon Became the World's Largest Co-Op | The New Yorker

<https://www.newyorker.com/business/currency/how-mondragon-became-the-worlds-largest-co-op>

⁹ ¹⁰ First Nations principles of OCAP - Wikipedia

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/First_Nations_principles_of_OCAP

¹¹ Lao Tzu - A leader is best when people barely know he...

https://www.brainyquote.com/quotes/lao_tzu_121709

¹² ¹³ ¹⁹ Asset-Based Community Development - Definition and Explanation

<https://oxford-review.com/the-oxford-review-dei-diversity-equity-and-inclusion-dictionary/asset-based-community-development-definition-and-explanation/>

¹⁴ Community Based Participatory Research | CA-PHE

<https://caphedetroit.sph.umich.edu/about-us/community-based-participatory-research/>

¹⁵ ¹⁶ ¹⁷ ¹⁸ Solidarity Economy | AWID

<https://www.awid.org/solidarity-economy>